

DEPARTMENT OF INTERIOR DESIGN
IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY
GRADUATE PROGRAMS HANDBOOK

Master of Fine Arts

Master of Arts

First Professional Master of Arts

Approval Date: [12/12/2025] by Interior Design Faculty

Prepared by Interior Design Graduate Program Committee (Yongyeon Cho, Sarah Zenti, Hamed Yekita) according to the Graduate College Handbook and Department of Interior Design Governance Document.

IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY
Department of Interior Design

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Chapter 1. Program Mission and Contact Information

1.1. Purpose of the Handbook

This handbook is intended to serve as a guide for graduate students in the Interior Design Department at Iowa State University. It describes program policies, degree requirements, procedures, expectations, and resources related to Interior Design. It should be used in conjunction with the Iowa State University Graduate College Handbook, which provides university-wide rules, rights, and responsibilities. The goal is to help graduate students navigate their degree journey smoothly, clarify what is required, and support your academic and professional success.

1.2. Overview of the Graduate Program

The Interior Design Department offers three graduate degree options:

- **MFA in Interior Design:** A terminal post-professional degree emphasizing advanced creative achievement.
- **MA in Interior Design:** A post-professional degree focused on applied design research and analysis.
- **First-Professional MA in Interior Design:** Combines entry-level preparation with advanced knowledge of interior design analysis and research, for students without a professional undergraduate background in interior design or related fields.

Through coursework, studio projects, research, and hands-on experiences, the Department prepares graduate students to become designers, researchers, and educators who enhance human experience and improve built, cultural, and social environments.

1.3. Program Mission Statement

The mission of the Department of Interior Design is to educate students to become successful designers and scholars who enhance human experience and improve built, cultural, and social environments through interior design. The graduate programs emphasize innovation, creativity, collaboration, and experimentation, preparing graduates to engage with contemporary challenges through scholarship, design practice, and leadership.

1.4. Interior Design Graduate Faculty and Staff Directory

The information below is updated in Fall 2025.

- **Department Chair:** [Kotaro Nakamura](#)
- **Director of Graduate Education (DoGE):** [Yongyeon Cho](#)
- **Graduate Faculty:** [Dr. Julie Irish](#), [Nicole Peterson](#), [Dr. Hamed Yekita](#), and [Sarah Zenti](#)
- **Graduate Student Support:** [Anne Grevstad-Nordbrock](#)
- **Graduate Student Recruiter:** [Melissa Stenstrom](#)

1.5. Program Learning Outcomes

Graduates of the Interior Design graduate programs at Iowa State University will be able to:

- **Integrate Research and Design:** Apply advanced research methods, theories, and evidence-based approaches to generate original interior design scholarship and creative work.
- **Demonstrate Advanced Design Competence:** Develop and execute innovative design solutions that respond to human, social, cultural, and environmental needs across diverse contexts.
- **Communicate Effectively:** Present design ideas and research findings with clarity in written, oral, and visual forms to academic, professional, and public audiences.
- **Exhibit Cultural and Historical Awareness:** Analyze and interpret cultural, historical, and theoretical perspectives that shape interior environments.
- **Engage in Professional and Ethical Practice:** Demonstrate ethical responsibility, inclusivity, and leadership in design practice, research, and interdisciplinary collaboration.

Chapter 2. Getting Started & Resource

2.1. Graduate Handbook

The Iowa State University Graduate College Handbook is the authoritative guide for all graduate students. It outlines policies and procedures related to admission, registration, grading, academic standing, degree requirements, assistantship, examinations, and graduation. The Interior Design Graduate Programs Handbook should be read as a supplement. In any case of conflict, the Graduate College Handbook is the governing document. Students are strongly recommended to review the Graduate College Handbook regularly: [Graduate College Handbook](#).

2.2. College of Design Website

The [College of Design Website](#) provides current information about college-wide resources, programs, faculty and staff information, events, and facilities. Students can access information about technology support, labs, model shops, study abroad, advising, and student organizations. The site also contains links to academic calendars, course descriptions, and policies relevant to all design students.

2.3. Interior Design Graduate Program Websites

The Interior Design Graduate Program websites are the primary source for program-specific information, including admissions, curriculum sheets, and prerequisite requirements. It provides updated information on courses, program policies, and graduate student resources.

- [Master of Fine Arts in Interior](#)
- [Master of Arts in Interior Design](#)
- [First Professional Master of Arts in Interior Design](#)

2.4. Graduate Studios & Studio Policy

Graduate students in Interior Design are free to use room 211 in the College of Design building whenever available. Studios provide an environment that encourages collaboration, peer learning, and exchange of ideas across cohorts. Students are expected to maintain professional standards of cleanliness, safety, and shared responsibility in all studio spaces.

- Desk and storage areas must be kept orderly.
- Materials, tools, and models must be stored safely to avoid hazards.
- Studio resources are communal; respect for colleagues' work and equipment is essential.

The studio is considered a professional workspace. Students should model the same responsibility and ethics expected in professional design practice.

2.5. Communication

Email is the official mode of communication at Iowa State University. All graduate students are required to activate and regularly check their @iastate.edu email account, which will be used for program announcements, course communication, and official university correspondence. Faculty, staff, and the DoGE will send important information only to ISU email addresses, and students are expected to read and respond in a timely and professional manner. Students, faculty, and staff use Outlook for scheduling and meetings. The program and faculty will send Outlook calendar invitations for advising sessions, committee meetings, reviews, and other important events. Students are expected to accept or decline invitations promptly and manage their calendars responsibly.

In addition to email, the program also uses Canvas – ISU Interior Design Graduate Program Information as a central communication platform. Announcements will be posted there, and students can find useful resources such as master's graduation deadlines, the graduate student checklist, student & major professor checklist, graduate student form links, and annual curriculum sheets. Students are expected to check Canvas regularly to stay updated on program information and requirements.

2.6. Role of the Director of Graduate Education

The Director of Graduate Education (DoGE) is the faculty member who coordinates the Interior Design graduate programs and serves as the main connection between the department and the Graduate College. The DoGE is elected by the Interior Design Faculty to a three-year term and works closely with faculty, staff, and students to support the MFA and MA programs.

For graduate students, the DoGE is your first point of contact for questions about program requirements, policies, and procedures. The DoGE reviews and approves documents submitted to the Graduate College (such as your Academic Plan, committee appointments, and graduation paperwork) and ensures you are meeting important

deadlines. The DoGE also helps students understand program expectations, connect with resources, and resolve concerns that may come up during their studies. In your first semester, the DoGE will have an orientation session to inform the items in this graduate program handbook for new graduate students. The DoGE will serve as your initial advisor, helping you understand the curriculum and begin developing your Academic Plan. Once you select a major professor and form your Academic Plan Committee, the DoGE remains a resource for questions about program policies, teaching assistantships, and academic progress.

Please find more information from the Graduate Handbook: **A.1.3 Directors of Graduate Education (DOGE)**

Chapter 3. Degree Programs and Requirements

Course offerings and degree requirements are subject to change. Students must consult the **current ISU Catalog** and their **Academic Plan** to ensure compliance with the most up-to-date program requirements.

3.1. MFA Curriculum

The MFA in Interior Design is a five-semester, 60-credit program and the terminal degree in the field. It prepares students for professional practice, academic teaching, and design research. The program is designed for students with undergraduate degrees in Interior Design or related disciplines, as well as those from other fields who complete required prerequisites. The curriculum integrates seminars, advanced experimental studios, interdisciplinary option studios, electives, and a thesis with public exhibition.

Credit Requirements (60 credits):

- **Seminars** (12 credits): Human-Centered Interior Design, and Design Methods.
- **Methods** (3 credits): Research Methods.
- **Studios** (20 credits): Advanced Experimental Interior Design and Interdisciplinary Design Studios.
- **Interior Design Electives** (9 credits): Options include Advanced Visualization, Preservation & Cultural Heritage, Advanced Color Theory, Inclusive Environments, Lighting Design, Sustainability in Interior Environment, and others.
- **Thesis & Exhibition** (13 credits): Written thesis and public exhibition with a final oral examination (see 4.3 for more details).
- **Electives** (3 credits).

3.2. MA Curriculum

The post-professional MA in Interior Design is a three-semester, 34-credit program designed for students with undergraduate degrees in Interior Design or related disciplines, as well as those from other fields who complete required prerequisites. The curriculum integrates seminars, advanced experimental studios, interdisciplinary option studios, electives, and a thesis or a creative component.

Credit Requirements (34 credits):

- **Seminars** (9 credits): Human-Centered Interior Design, Design Methods.
- **Methods** (3 credits): Research Methods.
- **Studios** (10 credits): Advanced Experimental Interior Design and Interdisciplinary Design Studio.
- **Interior Design Electives** (6 credits): Options include Advanced Visualization, Preservation & Cultural Heritage, Advanced Color Theory, Inclusive Environments, Lighting Design, Sustainability in Interior Environment, and others.
- **Thesis or Creative Component** (6 credits): Written thesis or written creative component with a final oral examination (see 4.3 for more details).

3.3. First Professional MA Curriculum

The First-Professional Master of Arts (MA) in Interior Design is an 84-credit program designed for students who do not hold a professional undergraduate degree in Interior Design. The program provides both foundational preparation in design knowledge and technical skills, as well as advanced graduate-level study in research, human-centered design, and professional practice. Students typically complete the program in three years of full-time study. The curriculum integrates undergraduate-level prerequisites in interior design with graduate seminars, advanced experimental studios, interdisciplinary option studios, electives, and a thesis or a creative component.

Credit Requirements (84 credits):

- **Undergraduate-Level Requirements** (50 credits): Includes design foundations, history/theory, construction, lighting, regulations, finish materials, human factors, graphic communication, internships, and multiple design studios.
- **Graduate-Level Requirements** (34 credits):
- **Seminars** (9 credits): Human-Centered Interior Design, Design Methods.
- **Methods** (3 credits): Research Methods.
- **Studios** (10 credits): Advanced Experimental Interior Design and Interdisciplinary Design Studio.
- **Interior Design Electives** (6 credits): Options include Advanced Visualization, Preservation & Cultural Heritage, Advanced Color Theory, Inclusive Environments, Lighting Design, Sustainability in Interior Environment, and others.

- **Thesis or Creative Component** (6 credits): Written thesis or written creative component with a final oral examination (see 4.3 for more details).

3.4. Double Degrees, Minors, and Certificates

Graduate students may enhance their academic plan with additional credentials:

- **Double Degrees:** The Department of Interior Design offers approved double-degree options in collaboration with other graduate programs at Iowa State University. Students may pursue the MA or MFA in Interior Design combined with the MS in Human Computer Interaction (HCI) through the Interdepartmental Graduate Program in HCI.
- **Ph.D. in HCI:** Interior Design serves as a home department for students in the interdisciplinary HCI doctoral program.
- **Graduate Minors and Certificates:** Students may pursue graduate minors (*e.g., Graduate Minor in Industrial Design, Graduate Minor in Integrated Visual Arts, and Graduate Minor in Sustainable Environments*) or certificates (*Preservation and Cultural Heritage Certificate, Geographic Information Systems Certificate, Post-Baccalaureate Undergraduate Certificate in Integrated Studio Arts, and Human Computer Interaction – Graduate Certificate*) to complement their studies.

Students interested in these opportunities should consult with the DoGE and their Academic Plan Committee early in their program to ensure all requirements are met.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **4.3.3 Double Degree Programs.**

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **4.1.4 Graduate Minor.**

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **4.1.6 Graduate Certificates.**

3.5. Departmental Policies

3.5.1. English-Language Requirements

All graduate students must meet the **English proficiency requirements** established by the Iowa State University Graduate College. International applicants are required to submit official test scores unless exempt under Graduate College policy. The

minimum scores are: TOEFL Paper (PBT) 550, TOEFL Internet (iBT) 79, IELTS 6.5, PTE 53, or Duolingo 115 (approved through Spring 2026).

In addition, some students may be required to complete the English Placement Test (EPT) upon arrival. Based on the results, students may be asked to enroll in English language support courses. These courses are designed to strengthen academic writing, reading, speaking, and listening skills, but they do not count toward the graduate degree audit.

3.5.2. Computer Requirements

Students in Interior Design are required to have a laptop computer that meets or exceeds the College of Design's hardware and software specifications published each year on the [Student Computer Requirements page](#). These requirements ensure that students can successfully run design and visualization software and fully participate in coursework. Students should read the specific requirements for Interior Design carefully when selecting and maintaining their computer.

The department does not provide or cover student software licenses. Students are responsible for purchasing and maintaining licensed software on their personal computers. However, students have access to College of Design [Computer Labs](#) on the 4th floor, which include the necessary software for coursework. The College of Design also provides a [Laptop Program](#), which helps students purchase laptops with the required specifications. In addition, students regularly use the [Output Center](#) for large-format printing, 3D printing, laser cutting, and other production needs that support coursework and studio projects.

3.5.3. Credit Waiver and Concurrent Degree Program

Credit Waiver

Graduate students who have completed equivalent graduate-level coursework at another accredited institution in Interior Design or a closely related discipline may petition to have those credits transferred or waived. This includes students who have previously graduated from Iowa State's Interior Design program and have completed graduate-level (5000-level or higher) Interior Design courses elsewhere or at ISU that might overlap with new program requirements.

Any such transfer or waiver request must be clearly documented in your Academic Plan and approved by your Academic Plan Committee and the DoGE along with the Graduate College. Supporting documentation—such as official transcripts and course syllabi or outlines—may be required to evaluate equivalency. To avoid delays in

degree progress, students are strongly recommended to submit their waiver requests as early as possible—ideally by the second semester of graduate study. If the request is made later, it may still be considered, but students must be aware that sequencing of required courses, time to degree, or eligibility for certain program opportunities might be affected.

Concurrent Degree Program

The Concurrent Degree Program allows students to pursue a graduate degree while simultaneously completing their undergraduate degree at Iowa State University.

- Students may apply up to (12) twelve ISU credits of coursework for MFA program, 6 ISU credits of course work for MA program to count toward both their undergraduate and graduate degree requirements, with approval from both programs and the Graduate College.
- Students must apply and be formally admitted to the concurrent program before registering for courses to be double-counted.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **4.3.2 Concurrent Degree Programs - Concurrent Bachelor's/Professional Degrees with a Graduate Certificate or Master's Program**

3.5.4. Grading & Academic Standing

Graduate students must maintain a minimum cumulative GPA of 3.00 to remain in good academic standing as required by the Graduate College. A cumulative GPA below 3.00 may result in academic probation. All courses listed on the student's Academic Plan must be completed before graduation and must carry a minimum grade of C. Courses with grades lower than C cannot be used to fulfill degree requirements.

In the Department of Interior Design, all culminating requirements — including the thesis, creative component, and exhibition — are evaluated with a letter grade. This ensures that students' performance in these components is reflected in their GPA.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **8.6 - Maintaining Academic Standing** and **8.7 - Dismissal for Failure to Maintain Academic Standing**

3.5.5. Absences

Graduate students are expected to attend all scheduled classes, studios, reviews, exhibitions, program meetings, and related activities. Regular participation is essential for maintaining progress and contributing to the learning environment of the

department. Students who anticipate an absence due to illness, family emergency, religious observance, or professional obligations (such as official Iowa State field trips, conferences, or workshops) must notify their course instructor prior to the absence whenever possible, and no later than the day of the absence.

For extended absences of more than three consecutive class or studio days, or for conflicts with major program activities (such as reviews, exhibitions, or milestone requirements), students should also notify the DoGE in writing. Students remain responsible for completing any missed readings, assignments, studios, or examinations. Unapproved or repeated absences may negatively affect course grades, evaluations, and standing in the program.

3.5.6. Annual Graduate Student Progress Check

Each year, graduate students in Interior Design complete a progress review with the DoGE. Reviews take place at the end of the spring semester (in April) and are intended to confirm timely progress toward degree completion, good academic standing, and alignment with program expectations.

Prior to the meeting, students must submit a written self-report that includes:

- The semester and year they entered the program, their current year/semester of study, and their expected semester of graduation.
- A summary of the progress you made in the year for the thesis or the creative component.
- What are the strengths of your work and progress this year?
- What challenges did you encounter?
- What goals will you set for the coming year?
- If you don't have your major professor and committee members, who might be your professor and committee members?
- If you have the major professor and committee members, how have your major professor and committee supported your progress?
- What resources or support would help you move forward?

During the meeting, the DoGE will provide feedback and guidance. The student's written self-report will serve as the official documentation of the annual review.

3.5.7. Academic Misconduct

All graduate students are expected to uphold the highest standards of academic integrity in coursework, research, and creative work. Misconduct includes plagiarism, fabrication, falsification, unauthorized collaboration, or misuse of university resources.

Alleged violations will be addressed following the policies outlined in the Graduate College Handbook Chapter 8.4 - Specific Policies and Laws of Interest to Graduate Students and the Iowa State University [Student Code of Conduct](#). For more information on what constitutes academic misconduct or how cases are handled, refer to [Prohibited Conduct - Academic Misconduct](#) and the [Know the Code Resources for Students](#).

Consequences for confirmed violations may include a failing grade in a course, probation, suspension, or dismissal from the program, depending on severity and prior history.

3.5.8. Grievances and Appeals

Graduate students who believe they have been treated unfairly in academic or program matters have the right to file a grievance or appeal. Students are recommended to first attempt resolution informally with the instructor, advisor, or faculty member involved. If this is not possible, or if the matter remains unresolved, the student may bring the issue to the DoGE, the Department Chair, or directly to the Graduate College. Formal grievance and appeal procedures are governed by the Graduate College Handbook, Chapter 8.5 - Student Grievance Procedures, and students must review those guidelines for detailed steps and timelines.

Within the Department of Interior Design, grievances will be reviewed by the Departmental Ad-Hoc Grievance Committee. This committee will consist of two graduate faculty members and two graduate students from the department. The DoGE or the Department Chair will serve as the chair of the committee. In the event of a tie vote, the chair is permitted to cast the deciding vote. To ensure impartiality, individuals directly involved in the matter under review will not serve as members of the committee. If necessary, a graduate faculty member from another department within the College of Design may be appointed to the committee. All proceedings of the committee will remain strictly confidential. The department's goal is to resolve concerns fairly, promptly, and at the lowest appropriate level, while ensuring students have access to formal mechanisms for appeal through the Graduate College if necessary.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **8.5 - Student Grievance Procedures**

3.7. Curriculum Practical Training and Optional Practical Training

International students in F-1 status may be eligible for Curriculum Practical Training (CPT) or Optional Practical Training (OPT) to gain practical work experience related to their degree.

- CPT must be an integral part of the academic program, and students are required to register for a CPT-related course and receive authorization from ISSO before beginning work. Registration means the student takes credit, and the associated tuition and fees apply as with other courses. The department recommends ARTID 6970: Design Practicum (3 credits), taken under the guidance of the graduate student's major professor, which may also be included in the Academic Plan. More details are available on the [ISSO CPT](#) website.
- OPT allows up to (12) twelve months of work authorization in the U.S. related to interior design following completion of the MA or MFA degree. Students must meet eligibility requirements, including good academic standing and completion of required coursework and the thesis or creative component. Students completing a double degree that includes a STEM-designated program (such as Architecture or HCI, if eligible) may also qualify for a 24-month STEM OPT extension, for a total of up to 36 months. Details and application timelines are available on the [ISSO OPT](#) website and [STEM OPT](#) website.

Chapter 4. Graduate Academic Plan and Committee

4.1. Academic Plan Committee Makeup

The Academic Plan Committee ensures that a student's program meets academic standards and supports their scholarly and professional goals. The Graduate College requires that all committees include graduate faculty, with specific composition depending on the degree type.

- **Master of Fine Arts (MFA):** The committee must consist of at least three members of the graduate faculty. One must be the major professor (chair), one additional member must be from the Interior Design graduate faculty, and one member must be from outside the department.
- **Master of Arts (MA) – Thesis:** The committee must consist of at least three members of the graduate faculty. One must be the major professor, one additional member must be from the Interior Design graduate faculty, and one member must be from outside the department.
- **Master of Arts (MA) – Creative Component (Non-Thesis):** The committee must consist of at least two members of the graduate faculty. One must be the major professor from the Interior Design graduate faculty, and the other must also be from the graduate faculty.
- **Double Degrees:** For students pursuing double degrees (such as MA/MFA in Interior Design with MS in HCI), the Academic Plan Committee must meet the minimum requirements of both programs. This typically means at least three graduate faculty, with representation from both participating programs and at least one member outside the home department.
- **For MA/MFA in Interior Design + MA in HCI double degrees,** an Interior Design faculty member who also holds HCI graduate faculty status may serve as the major professor, fulfilling requirements for both programs. In this case, students must still include another Interior Design graduate faculty member and one outside member to meet Graduate College rules (typically 3 committee members).

Note: All committees must be approved in Workday and by the Graduate College.

Note: Changes to the Academic Plan Committee may be requested and must follow Graduate College procedures as outlined in Graduate Handbook **Section 6.2.6 – Academic Plan Committee (APC) Changes.**

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **6.1 - Academic Plan Committee (APC)**

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **Appendix - G: Graduate Faculty Membership & Associate Membership**

4.1.1. Graduate Student's responsibilities

Graduate students are responsible for the timely and successful completion of all degree requirements. Specifically, students must:

- Select a major professor and, in consultation with the major professor, form an Academic Plan Committee.
- Develop and maintain the Academic Plan in Workday, ensuring it reflects degree requirements, electives, and program expectations.
- Schedule and attend regular committee meetings, providing materials to the major professor and committee in advance.
- Communicate regularly with the major professor and committee members regarding academic progress and deadlines.
- Comply with departmental and Graduate College requirements, policies, and timelines.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **6.4.3 Student Responsibilities**

4.1.2. Major Professor Responsibilities

The major professor serves as the student's primary advisor and mentor, chairs the Academic Plan Committee, and has primary responsibility for supervising the student's academic and creative/research work. Please use this [checklist](#) to discuss before fully engage this relationship. Responsibilities include:

- Guiding the development of the Academic Plan and ensuring compliance with departmental and Graduate College requirements.
- Advising on coursework, research, and professional development opportunities.
- Coordinating committee activities, including scheduling meetings, overseeing evaluations, and preparing the student for the final oral examination.
- Providing regular and timely feedback on student progress and written work.

- Ensuring that all Graduate College forms and evaluations related to the student's progress are submitted appropriately.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **6.4.1 Major Professor Responsibilities.**

4.1.3. Committee Member's responsibilities

Committee members contribute expertise and help ensure academic quality. Responsibilities include:

- Reviewing and approving the Academic Plan and subsequent revisions.
- Attending scheduled committee meetings, including proposal reviews, progress evaluations, and the final oral examination.
- Providing timely, constructive feedback on research, creative work, and thesis/creative component drafts.
- Voting on the final oral examination in accordance with Graduate College policy.
- Sharing responsibility with the major professor for verifying that the student has met all program and Graduate College requirements.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **6.4.2 Academic Plan Committee (APC) Member Responsibilities.**

4.2. Academic Plan

The Academic Plan outlines the student's program of study, including required coursework, electives, thesis or creative components, and program expectations toward the degree. It serves as a formal agreement between the student, the Academic Plan Committee, and the Graduate College.

4.2.1. Developing Academic Plan

Graduate students, in consultation with their major professor, are responsible for developing the Academic Plan. The plan must reflect the degree requirements approved by the department and the Graduate College. Students are recommended to draft their Academic Plan during the first year of study to ensure timely progress. Early preparation also allows for the approval of transfer credits or course waivers, where appropriate.

Before a major professor is selected, the DoGE serves as the official advisor. Students must discuss their Academic Plan with the DoGE until a major professor is identified. It is strongly recommended that MA students secure a major professor in their first semester and that MFA students do so by their first or second semester, in order to begin developing a clear plan of study.

To create the Academic Plan, students must use the curriculum sheet they received upon entering the program. This document serves as a guide for required courses, electives, and program expectations. Curriculum sheets may change as the departmental curriculum evolves and as faculty teaching assignments shift. Students should consult their major professor and the DoGE if questions arise about course availability or substitutions.

4.2.2. Academic Plan in Workday

When the Academic Plan Committee has been formed, students must enter the membership in Workday (refer to [KB0025058](#)). Students may update committee information as needed, including changes to roles, removal, or replacement of members, in accordance with Graduate College policy.

The Academic Plan is submitted and maintained through Workday (refer to [KB0023078](#)). Students initiate the plan in Workday, list required and elective courses and route the plan to their Academic Plan Committee for review. Once approved by the committee, the plan is submitted to the Graduate College for final approval.

Students must check Academic Plan Committee and Academic Plan deadlines on the [graduate college website](#). Both must be filed in Workday before the Graduate College will approve scheduling of the final oral examination. Students are required to submit the Academic Plan Committee before submitting the Academic Plan. These should be completed at least (6) six months before the expected graduation date. To ensure timely review and avoid delays in coursework, examinations, or graduation, students are strongly encouraged to submit both (9) nine months prior to their anticipated graduation semester.

Students are expected to update their Academic Plan if significant changes occur, such as course substitutions or committee membership changes. The Academic Plan remains a living document and must accurately always reflect the student's degree progress.

4.3. Components of Thesis, Exhibition, and Creative Component

Graduate students in Interior Design complete the listed culminating component(s), depending on their degree track and Academic Plan. Each demonstrates advanced scholarly ability (building upon prior knowledge, peer-reviewed, and disseminated) and creative ability (originality and uniqueness), contributes to the discipline, and fulfills Graduate College requirements for a culminating experience. The Graduate student and the Major Professor will have an agreement on the content, quality, and quantity of the thesis, exhibition, and creative component.

4.3.1. Thesis

The thesis is a written document that demonstrates original research, scholarly rigor, and a contribution to the field of interior design. It must:

- Identify a significant research question or problem.
- Situate the work within relevant literature and precedent.
- Apply appropriate research methods.
- Present findings with clarity and critical analysis.

The thesis must follow Graduate College formatting guidelines and be approved by the Academic Plan Committee. It culminates in a final oral examination, which includes a public presentation. After successful defense and revisions, the thesis is submitted to the Graduate College through the ISU Digital Repository.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **7.1.4 Dissertation or Thesis** and visit the [website](#) for policies and guidelines from graduate college.

Please find the **Thesis Format Requirements** from this [website](#).

4.3.2. Exhibition

The exhibition is a requirement for the MFA degree. It presents the thesis and creative design work based on research. The exhibition combines scholarly writing (including research outcomes and justification of the design work) with the creative design work, represented visually or through installations. It emphasizes the integration of theory, research, and design practice, demonstrating how interior design knowledge can be communicated through both written and spatial/visual media. Requirements include:

- A summary of the research outcomes for the development of the creative design work

- Justifications and explanations of the creative design work.
- A public exhibition of the creative design work with visual representation or installations.

MFA students must also document the justification of the creative design work, the design outcomes, and the exhibition itself in the thesis. Possible exhibition locations are not limited to the College of Design building or the Student Innovation Center. Please decide the location and schedule of the exhibition with consultation with the major professor.

4.3.3. Creative Component

The creative component is a written and design-based project emphasizing applied research and design solutions. It is typically suited for students in the MA program. The creative component must:

- Address a significant issue in interior design practice or education.
- Include a written document that provides scholarly grounding which is review of relevant literature and justification of a creative design work.
- The creative design work must be presented in visual and oral formats.

The creative component must follow the Graduate College Creative Component template and requirement checklist and be approved by the Academic Plan Committee. It culminates in a final oral examination, which includes a public presentation. The written document is submitted to the Graduate College through the ISU Digital Repository.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **7.1.5 Creative Component**.

Please find the **Creative Component Format Requirements** from this [website](#).

4.4. Program Requirements

4.4.1. Thesis Proposal and Creative Component Proposal

Students are required to prepare a written proposal that serves as the foundation for their graduate project (thesis, exhibition, or creative component). The proposal is both an academic document and a professional tool: it demonstrates readiness for graduate-level inquiry, and it provides a means of inviting faculty to serve as the major professor and, later, as members of the Academic Plan Committee.

- **Process:**
 - Students should first draft a proposal to invite a faculty member to serve as major professor.
 - Once the faculty member agrees serve on as a major professor, the proposal must be further developed in consultation with the major professor.
 - The refined proposal is then used to invite potential members of the Academic Plan Committee.
 - A formal meeting must be held, where the Academic Plan Committee reviews and approves the proposal before the student may advance to thesis research, exhibition preparation, or creative component work.
- **Content and Format:** The proposal must:
 - Be 500–700 words in length, not including references.
 - State the purpose, objectives, and central research/design questions.
 - Provide a review of relevant literature and precedent, citing 5–10 scholarly or professional references.
 - Outline the methods, strategies, or design approaches to be employed.
 - Define the expected outcomes and contributions to the discipline.
 - Include a proposed timeline for completion.
- **Degree-Specific Expectations:**
 - MFA Students: In addition to the written proposal, MFA students must include preliminary documentation of the creative design work to be developed for the exhibition.
 - MA Students: Must choose between a thesis or creative component; the proposal should reflect the chosen path.

4.4.2. Academic Plan Committee Meetings

The Academic Plan Committee provides ongoing guidance and evaluation of the student's progress. Committee meetings are an essential part of graduate study, ensuring that the student remains on track toward successful completion of degree requirements.

- **Required Meetings:** Students must schedule and hold committee meetings for:

- Proposal Defense – formal presentation of the thesis, exhibition, or creative component proposal.
- Progress Review – held to review research/design development, and overall progress.
- Final Oral Examination – defense of the thesis, exhibition, or creative component, which also serves as the Graduate College-required final exam.
- **Additional Meetings:** Students, the major professor, or the committee may request additional meetings at any point if progress concerns arise or further guidance is needed.

Students are responsible for coordinating meeting times, preparing and distributing materials to committee members in advance, and ensuring that outcomes of the meeting are documented and shared with the committee. The major professor chairs all meetings and communicates outcomes to the DoGE and Graduate College when required.

4.4.3. Final Oral Examination

All graduate students must complete a final oral examination, which is both a Graduate College requirement and the culminating evaluation of the degree.

- **Format:** The examination includes a public presentation of the thesis, exhibition, or creative component, followed by a closed session with the Academic Plan Committee.
- **Purpose:** The exam evaluates:
 - The quality, originality, and significance of the research or creative work.
 - The written document and its adherence to Graduate College requirements.
 - The student's ability to articulate findings, defend methodology or design decisions, and respond to scholarly critique.
- **Preparation:** Students must provide the final version of the written thesis or creative component to all committee members at least two weeks before the scheduled final oral examination. This ensures adequate time for review. MFA students must also include documentation of the exhibition as part of their final materials.

- **Scheduling:** The final oral examination must be scheduled in accordance with Graduate College deadlines for the term of graduation. Students can schedule the final oral examination only in the Spring or Fall semester. The student is responsible for filing the required forms in Workday and coordinating with the Graduate College to announce the final oral examination.
- **Outcomes:** The committee votes to determine the result of the examination (pass, conditional pass with required revisions, or fail). A conditional pass requires completion of revisions within a specified timeframe set by the committee. Successful completion of the final oral examination, along with submission of the approved written document to the ISU Digital Repository, is required for graduation.

Note on Degree Requirements: MFA students must complete both a written thesis AND a public exhibition, culminating in the final oral examination. MA students must complete either a written thesis OR a written creative component, both culminating in the final oral examination.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **7.1.2 Final Oral Examinations**

4.5. Applying for Graduation Process

Students must formally apply for graduation through Workday Student in the semester in which they intend to graduate. Graduate College deadlines for application and submission are published each semester on the [Graduate College website](#).

To be approved for graduation, students must:

- Complete all coursework and program requirements as outlined in their Academic Plan.
- Successfully defend the thesis, exhibition, or creative component in the final oral examination.
- Resolve any outstanding grades, revisions, or conditions noted by the committee.
- Submit the final approved document to the ISU Digital Repository by the Graduate College deadline.

It is the student's responsibility to verify that all Graduate College forms (e.g., committee approvals, exam scheduling forms, final submission forms) are filed correctly

in Workday. Students are recommended to consult with their major professor early in their final semester to ensure that all requirements and deadlines are met.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **7.1.8 Graduate Student Approval Request for Graduation.**

4.6. Program Timeline and Expectations

- **MFA in Interior Design (5 semesters)**
 - **Semester 1:** Begin seminars and advanced studio; meet with DoGE; explore potential thesis/exhibition topics.
 - **Semester 2:** Select major professor; begin drafting Academic Plan; identify potential Academic Plan Committee members; continue developing thesis/exhibition proposal.
 - **Semester 3:** Form Academic Plan Committee; file Academic Plan in Workday; hold first committee meeting to present proposal and discuss exhibition plan.
 - **Semester 4:** Submit IRB (if applicable); begin focused research/design development; present progress to the Academic Plan Committee.
 - **Semester 5:** Continue research/design work; complete written thesis; mount exhibition (ideally three weeks before the final oral examination); share the final thesis to the academic plan committee two weeks before; complete final oral examination; submit final documents and graduation paperwork.
- **Post-Professional MA in Interior Design (3 semester)**
 - **Semester 1:** Select major professor; begin coursework and studios; draft Academic Plan; develop thesis or creative component proposal.
 - **Semester 2:** Form Academic Plan Committee; file Academic Plan in Workday; hold first committee meeting early in the semester to present proposal; submit IRB (if applicable); present progress to the Academic Plan Committee at the end of the semester.
 - **Semester 3:** Continue research/design work; complete written thesis or creative component; share the final thesis or creative component to the academic plan committee two weeks before; complete final oral examination; submit final documents and graduation paperwork.
- **First Professional MA in Interior Design (6 semester)**

- **Semesters 1–2:** Begin foundational coursework and design studios; DoGE serves as advisor.
- **Semester 3:** Select major professor; continue coursework and studios; draft Academic Plan; develop thesis or creative component proposal.
- **Semester 4:** Form Academic Plan Committee; file Academic Plan in Workday; hold first committee meeting to present thesis or creative component proposal.
- **Semester 5:** Submit IRB (if applicable); begin focused research/design development; present progress to the Academic Plan Committee.
- **Semester 6:** Continue research/design work; complete written thesis or creative component; share the final thesis or creative component to the academic plan committee two weeks before; complete final oral examination; submit final documents and graduation paperwork.

Chapter 5. Graduate Assistantship Policy

5.1. Graduate Assistantships

Graduate assistantships provide both financial support and professional development opportunities for graduate students. Assistantships are awarded on a competitive basis and may be offered either Teaching Assistantships (TA) or research assistantships (RA). Graduate assistants are considered employees of Iowa State University and must meet the eligibility requirements (see 5.2. Graduate Assistantship Requirements). Appointments are typically for One-Quarter-Time time (10 hours per week).

In exchange for their service, graduate assistants receive:

- A monthly stipend
- A resident tuition
- A health and dental insurance

Assistantship offers are made by the department in consultation with the Graduate College. Renewal depends on satisfactory academic progress, strong performance in the assistantship role, and program needs.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **3.1 - Graduate Assistantships**.

For more information refer to the graduate handbook - **3.1.4 Benefits for Graduate Assistants**.

5.1.1. Teaching Assistantship

Teaching assistantships support the instructional mission of the Interior Design program. Responsibilities may include:

- Assisting faculty with course preparation and instructional materials.
- Leading discussions, conversations, or breakout sections.
- Supporting or providing studio critiques and feedback.
- Grading assignments, providing written comments, checking attendance, or assisting with exams in consultation with the instructor.
- Helping manage Canvas sites or instructional technology.

At the beginning of each appointment, the TA and supervising instructor(s) must hold an initial meeting to clarify duties and expectations. These responsibilities must be documented to [Graduate Assistant Worksheet Form](#) and shared with the DoGE for accountability.

Graduate assistants must also complete the [Graduate Assistant Hour Report Form](#) each payroll period, documenting actual hours worked and submitting it for supervisor approval.

In certain cases, advanced graduate students who demonstrate strong preparation and teaching ability may be assigned as the Instructor of Record for undergraduate courses. Such assignments require departmental approval and must comply with Graduate College policies.

5.1.2. Research Assistantship

Research assistantships provide opportunities to contribute to faculty research, creative scholarship, and funded projects. Responsibilities vary depending on the nature of the project but may include:

- Conducting literature reviews or precedent studies
- Collecting and analyzing data (qualitative, quantitative, or design-based)
- Supporting design development and visualization tasks
- Assisting with grant writing, reports, or presentations
- Preparing publications, exhibitions, or conference materials

At the beginning of each appointment, the RA and supervising faculty member(s) must hold an initial meeting to clarify duties and expectations. These responsibilities must be documented to [Graduate Assistant Worksheet Form](#) and shared with the DoGE for accountability.

Graduate assistants must also complete the [Graduate Assistant Hour Report Form](#) each payroll period, documenting actual hours worked and submitting it for supervisor approval.

Research assistantships are closely aligned with faculty expertise and funded research agendas, giving students practical experience in research methods, design inquiry, and professional dissemination.

5.2. Graduate Assistantship Requirements

To hold an assistantship, graduate students must:

- Be enrolled full time (minimum 9 credits during fall and spring, 5 credits during summer).
- Maintain a cumulative GPA of 3.0 or higher.
- Satisfactorily perform assigned duties as outlined in the letters of Intent.
- Complete all mandatory university training (e.g., Title IX, FERPA, Workplace Harassment Prevention, etc.).

5.3. Graduate Assistantship Assignments

Assistantship assignments are made by the Department Chair and DoGE in consultation with faculty, based on program needs, student qualifications, and available funding. Appointments are typically made on a semester-by-semester basis, although multi-semester appointments may be possible depending on funding.

5.3.1. Serving as Instructor of Record

In some cases, qualified graduate students may serve as the Instructor of Record for undergraduate courses. To be eligible, students must have completed at least 18 graduate credits in Interior Design or related disciplines, demonstrate teaching competence, and receive approval from the Department Chair and DoGE. Students serving as Instructor of Record are expected to adhere to all departmental and university instructional policies.

5.3.2. Training and Resources for Class Activity

Teaching assistants and graduate students serving as instructors of record are strongly recommended to participate in training sessions offered by the Graduate College (such as “Teaching Assistant Training”), the College of Design, and the Center for Excellence in Learning and Teaching (CELT). These trainings help ensure that graduate assistants are prepared to support high-quality instruction and comply with university standards.

The department provides access to course materials, shared instructional resources, and faculty mentoring. Each semester, the DoGE will provide a training session to inform the expectations as a graduate assistant. Graduate assistants are also recommended to take advantage of CELT workshops, seminars, and online teaching modules, which cover topics such as classroom management, inclusive teaching, assessment strategies, and use of instructional technology.

5.4. Graduate Assistant Evaluation Policy

All graduate assistants are formally evaluated at the end of each semester using the Department of Interior Design's [Graduate Assistant Evaluation Form](#). The evaluation is completed by the supervising faculty member or course coordinator and reviewed by the DoGE and Department Chair.

The evaluation considers performance in key areas, including:

- Knowledge of subject material relevant to the assignment.
- Proficiency in oral and written communication in instructional settings.
- Ability to evaluate student performance fairly and effectively.
- Facility with instructional materials and equipment appropriate to the course.

In addition, supervising faculty provide written comments on the assistant's strengths and areas for improvement. Graduate assistants are expected to review and sign their evaluation, which is then signed by the supervising instructor, the DoGE, and the Department Chair.

Students who receive an unsatisfactory or needs improvement rating may be placed on probation, have their appointment reduced or terminated, or be deemed ineligible for future funding. Evaluation records are kept in the department and may be considered in decisions about reappointment, fellowships, or awards.

Appendices.

A. List of Thesis and Publications from Interior Design Department

The department maintains an archive of graduate theses, exhibitions, and creative components completed by Interior Design students and faculty. The list of publications since 2012 is available through the ISU Digital Repository ([Department of Interior Design](#)) . Students are recommended to review past work for examples of scope, methodology, and formatting.

B. Forms

Graduate College and departmental forms are available online:

- [Graduate College Student Forms](#)
- [Graduate Assistant Worksheet Form](#)
- [Graduate Assistant Hour Report Form](#)
- [Graduate Assistant Evaluation Form](#)

C. Professional Associations & Student Clubs

Graduate students are encouraged to participate in professional and student organizations to expand their networks and develop leadership skills. Examples include:

- [IDSA](#) (Interior Design Student Association)
- [ISU Graduate and Professional Student Senate](#)
- [IDEC](#) (Interior Design Educators Council)
- [EDRA](#) (Environmental Design Research Association)
- [IIDA](#) (International Interior Design Association)
- [ASID](#) (American Society of Interior Designers)

D. College of Design Resources

The College of Design offers numerous resources for graduate students:

- [Design Student Resources Canvas Page](#)

- [IT Services](#): Student Computer Requirements, Laptop Program, Computer Labs, Output Center
- [College Facilities](#): Woodshop, Interior Design Material Lab, Student Innovation Center Makerspaces, Design Café.
- [Career Services](#): support for career planning, internships, and portfolio development.

E. University Resources

ISU provides a wide range of services for graduate students, including:

- [Graduate Student Checklist](#)
- [Graduate College: Deadlines](#)
- [Graduate College: Career](#), [Byond Grad School for Master's Students](#), [GoinGlobal](#), [Big Interview](#)
- [International Students & Scholars Office \(ISSO\)](#): [Graduate Students](#), [F-1 Students](#)
- [Center for Excellence in Learning & Teaching \(CELT\)](#)
- [Thesis/Dissertation Consultations](#)
- [Parks Library: Graduate Students](#)
- [Parking Services: For Students](#)
- [Student Counseling Services](#)
- [Ombuds Office](#)
- [Student Accessibility Services for Accommodations](#)

F. City Resources

Located in Ames, Iowa, students have access to:

- [CyRide](#): local public transportation system (free with ISU ID).
- [City of Ames](#): Government & Community Resources
- [Ames Public Library](#): community study spaces and services.